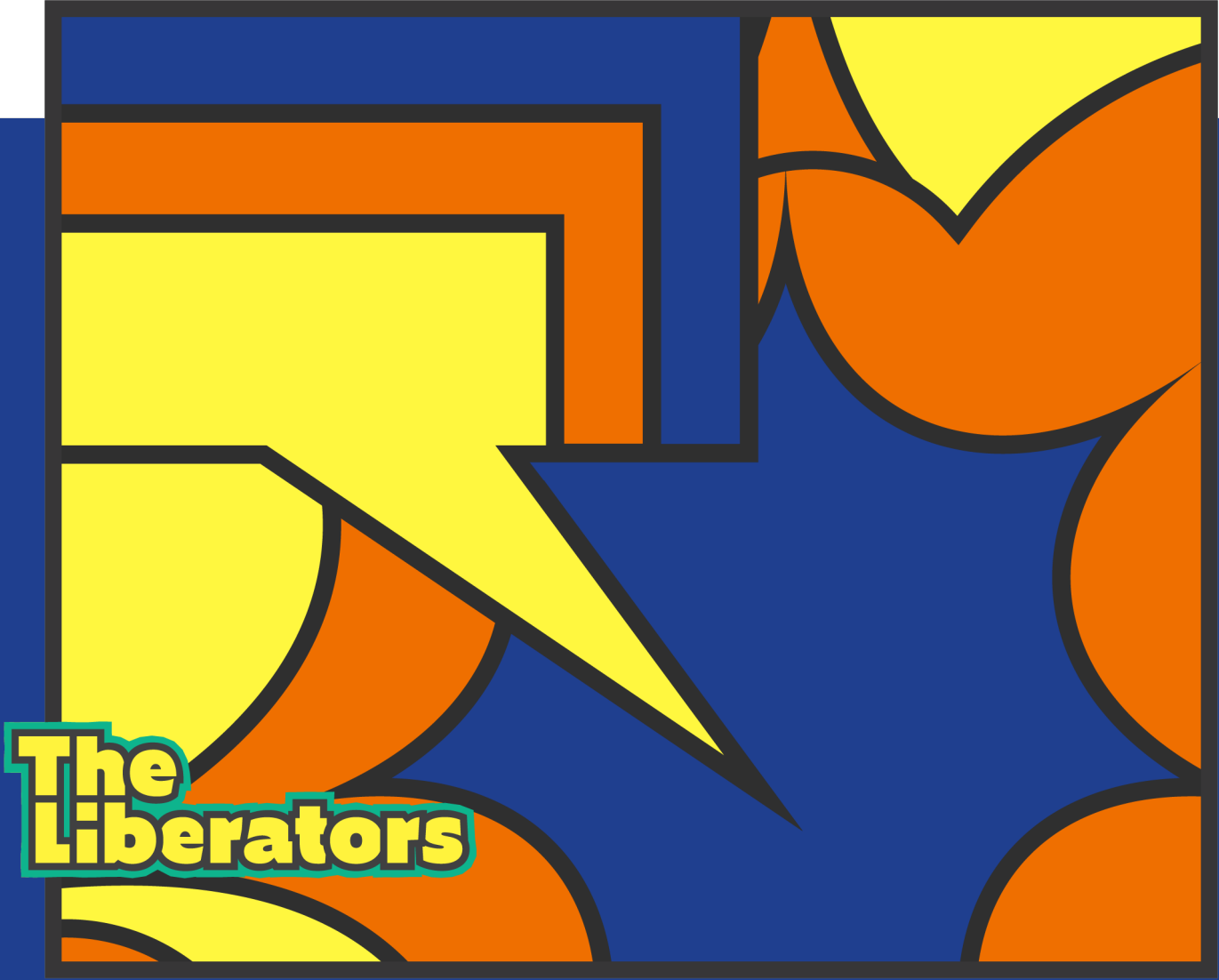


Help Your Team Get Started With A Product Goal And Sprint Goals

A do-it-yourself workshop to support your Scrum team clarify the Product- and Sprint Goal with Liberating Structures (e.g. UX Fishbowl, Conversation Cafe, and 25/10 Crowd Sourcing)

An abstract graphic featuring a dark blue background with large, bold, stylized shapes in orange and yellow. The shapes include a large yellow arrow pointing right, a yellow speech bubble, and several orange and yellow curved shapes. The text "The Liberators" is written in a bold, yellow, sans-serif font with a thick black outline and a slight shadow, positioned in the bottom left corner of the graphic.

**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

Product development is a complex endeavor. This is something you probably experienced yourself many times. The list of factors you can't predict is seemingly limitless. What features will our stakeholders value the most? How is the technology we have in mind going to work? What will our competitors do? Do we have all the necessary skills in our team? How much time will it take to finish this functionality? How easy are these bugs to fix?



A Scrum team can become overwhelmed when they try to figure out an answer to these questions. Especially, because once they get started, many new ideas, insights, and unexpected problems will emerge.

The importance of a goal quickly becomes clear; how else can the Scrum team make the trade-off on what to focus on? How do they even know the Sprint was successful? Luckily, the concept of "goals" became even more important in the recently updated [Scrum Guide](#). The Sprint Goal was already included but got extended with the Product Goal, the long-term objective for the product.

We designed this do-it-yourself workshop to help your Scrum team get started with a Product- and Sprint Goal. It doesn't matter if you're a new team or have already completed multiple Sprints. It's never too late to get started with how Scrum is intended. But the importance of a Product- and Sprint Goal is something you probably already experienced yourself...

The string of Liberating Structures contains UX Fishbowl to learn from the stakeholders, Conversation Cafe to share ideas & thoughts about the product, Nine Whys to create the Product Goal, and 25/10 Crowd Sourcing to select the Sprint Goals.

Give this string a try, and let us know the results.

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators

Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Learn More About The Product From Stakeholders With UX Fishbowl

  30 min

Step 3: Share Hopes, Fears, and Ideas With Conversation Cafe

  35 min

Step 4: Define The Product Goal With Nine Whys

  30 min

Step 5: Identify Sprint Goals With 25/10 Crowd Sourcing

  20 min

Step 6: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 120 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



Preparation is key. Share your expectation about the desired outcome upfront with the Product Owner and stakeholders. During the session, the structures we use here should do all the work.

Impact On Survival



If you have a clear Product- and Sprint Goal, it becomes progressively easier to build the right things.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 8 participants and onward. You can also run parallel sessions of this string at the same time, involving many more Scrum teams and many more stakeholders.

Intended Audience

This workshop is designed for one Scrum team and its stakeholders. For best effect, invite between 3 and 6 stakeholders that actually use, or will be using, your product on a regular basis.

It is important to invite [actual stakeholders](#). These are the people who have an actual stake in your work as a team, either because they invest significant amounts of time and/or money in it. An actual stakeholder is someone who clearly gains something when you deliver good work and loses something when you don't. Everyone else is your audience.

If you're unclear who your stakeholders are, you can create a [Stakeholder Map](#) first. Invite people in the "Promoters"-quadrant first, followed by the "Defenders"-quadrant and a few from the "Latents"-quadrant. If you have space, you can include participants from the "Audience"-quadrant.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Create a shared space (on a wall, the floor, or virtually) where you can collect insights from the various rounds.
- Create a shared space (on a wall, the floor, or virtually) where all the Product Backlog items are visible. This is obviously only relevant when you already have a Product Backlog.
- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.
- Prepare with your Product Owner and stakeholders to explain the intention of UX Fishbowl. This gives them the opportunity to already think of stories, experiences, and ideas they want to share about the product.
- Check how the free online app works for [25/10 Crowd Sourcing](#).



How Shared Goals Create Coherence



The Scrum Guide mentions the word "goal" 40 times, which is more than any other element of the Scrum framework. Now, we don't want to use this kind of exegesis to drive decisions about how to work with Scrum. But it should tell you something about how important shared goals are.

The reason why the Product Goal and the Sprint Goal are so important goes back to what the Scrum framework is designed for; to more effectively navigate complex problems and reduce their risk. Goals help us navigate this complexity in three complementary ways.

Goals Help Navigate Complexity

The first is that they offer guidance to the Scrum team when they have to make decisions about what to spend time on. Some work from the Sprint Backlog may be more important to achieving the Sprint Goal than others. The second is that this allows the team to keep their focus on what is important. When the going gets tough, as it often does, the team can decide to let go of certain work and prioritize other work. Or, when time permits, they can add work during the Sprint that they discover is necessary to achieve the goal. And third, Sprint Goals promote collaboration and coherence by giving the Scrum team a clear and shared purpose to self-manage around instead of working on separate initiatives. Collaboration makes possible the kind of out-of-the-box thinking and team spirit you need when solving complex problems.



Goals Give Purpose To The Scrum Events

The Product and Sprint Goal also give color and purpose to the various Scrum Events, elevating them beyond just being meetings about work. Sprint Planning is about determining the goal for the next Sprint and selecting the work that is needed for that. The Daily Scrum centers around how the Developers will spend the next 24 hours working towards this goal, and which impediments are blocking their ability to do so. The Sprint Review is about verifying the result of the Sprint Goal with stakeholders, how it relates to the Product Goal, and working with them to identify the next goals to focus on. The Sprint Retrospective is about discovering ways to work together more effectively to achieve Sprint Goals.

Goals Give Focus To The Three Roles Of Scrum

But the Product Goal and Sprint Goal also give focus to the three accountabilities of the Scrum framework. They give the Developers guidance and direction on what to self-manage around. They allow Product Owners to remain focused on their ambitions for the product and how that translates into objectives for the various Sprints, rather than involving themselves with the details of how to implement that. And finally, Scrum Masters can increase the effectiveness of empirical process control by using the Product Goal and Sprint Goal as the proverbial canary in the coal mine. When teams struggle to create goals, that is a good reason for Scrum Masters to put on their Sherlock hats and go explore what is causing this. Teams may be too large or small, they may lack certain skills or people. The Product Owner may not have a mandate or vision. Or refinement is not taking place.

This explanation should make it crystal clear why there should be only one Product Goal per product and one Sprint Goal per Sprint. Multiple goals only confuse the focus, decrease commitment, and limit transparency. Of course, a new goal can be formulated whenever the previous one is achieved or abandoned.

The short story is that in complex work, shared goals like Product Goals and Sprint Goals are the lighthouses that help you reach the harbor through dense fog. Without them, you're likely to get lost and run ashore.



3 min

Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose, introduce the stakeholders, and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.





Step 2: Learn More About The Product From Stakeholders With UX Fishbowl



If you don't have a Product Goal yet, ask your stakeholders to share their ideas, hopes, and fears about the product. Their thoughts and experiences provide excellent material for the Scrum team, in particular the Product Owner, to craft a Product Goal.

The Liberating Structure [User Experience Fishbowl](#) is a great way to encourage stakeholders to share stories and to listen to them. Stories about the purpose of the product, how it connects to the broader strategy they

have in mind, its success criteria, pitfalls they're worried about, features that are considered important. Try to gain as much information as possible from your stakeholders.

Invitation

"Imagine that the Scrum team has finished developing the product. What is the ideal result you have in mind? What problem does it solve? What features are definitely included? Who's using it? What have we achieved? What else?"

Steps

1. If you do this in-person, create an inner circle of chairs (3 to 7). Ask the stakeholders to take a seat in the inner circle (the fishbowl). Everyone else positions their seats in close concentric circles around the inner circle. If you do this virtually, the inner circle turns on microphones and webcams and everyone else turns theirs off.
2. **10 min** State the invitation of the UX Fishbowl and invite the inner circle to start an informal conversation about it, as if they're in a car together or at a coffee shop. The outer circles listen and observe with full attention, take notes and remain silent throughout.
3. **5 min** Invite everyone in the outer circles to form small groups (2-3 people) and use their notes to identify big questions that, when answered, might help create the Product Goal. Collect the questions so that the stakeholders can use them as input for the next round. If you do this step virtually, you can form break-out rooms for the small groups.
4. **10 min** Invite the inner circle to answer the submitted questions in whatever order works for them. The outer circles listen and take notes, and turn off their webcam and microphone when done virtually. Continue until all questions have been answered, or until the timebox expires.
5. **2 min** If the stakeholders don't stay the entire session, which is completely fine, then thank them for their contribution and explain the Product Goal will be shared with them afterward.

Our Findings

- UX Fishbowl works best when the participants share real, personal stories. Storytelling is a skill in itself. It can help if you put one person in the inner circle that helps the conversation flow. If you choose to do so, clarify your role upfront. This person doesn't contribute to sharing stories but can ask questions to keep the fishbowl alive.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- The [article](#) we wrote about User Experience Fishbowl
- Blog post: [Building Understanding Between Scrum Teams and Management with Liberating Structures](#)



Step 3: Share Hopes, Fears, and Ideas With Conversation Café

With UX Fishbowl, you learned more about the ideas, fears, and hopes the stakeholders have about the product. It should have given you insights about what problem the product should solve when it's considered successful, and what definitely must be prevented.

The Liberating Structure [Conversation Café](#) offers the Scrum team and the stakeholders the opportunity to explore their personal findings in more detail. Now that they've listened to the stakeholders, what seems to be important objectives or goals for the product?

Invitation

"Given the hopes, fears, and ideas that we've just heard, what seem to be important objectives or goals for our product"

Steps

1. If you do this in-person, ask people to form groups of 4 or 5 people. When done virtually, prepare breakouts. Make sure the stakeholders are distributed in different groups.
2. **2 min** Share the invitation for Conversation Café and give everyone some time to individually and silently reflect.
3. **2 min** Provide a rough overview of the rounds. Each group goes through four rounds, two first rounds with a talking object, the third one as an open conversation, and a final round to share personal insights again.
4. **2 min** Explain that, once everyone is in their small groups, they will self-manage the rounds. Ask for each group to pick a host. The host is a full participant whose role is to keep the timeboxes and to gently intervene when a participant fails to observe the timebox or is talking on and on.
5. **5 min** In the first round, everyone shares their personal thoughts and experience with regard to the selected invitation. Emphasize that this round is *not* a conversation.
6. **5 min** In the second round, everyone shares thoughts and feelings after having listened to everybody. Emphasize that this round is *not* a conversation.
7. **8 min** The third round is an open and lively conversation.
8. **5 min** In the fourth round, everyone shares their takeaways from the conversation. People have the option to pass.
9. **5 min** Briefly discuss the patterns that emerged with the entire group.

Our Findings

- It's helpful to keep the visual with all the steps visible while everyone is in the breakout rooms. You can prepare a Mural or Google Presentation that contains all the steps.
- Emphasize that groups should use talking objects. Participants can use whatever they prefer as a talking object, as long as they have one. A pen or marker that participants "pass around" is a fun way of using a talking object online. A good practice is that the person holding the talking object decides who goes next.
- Encourage people to really listen. In the first two rounds and in the final round, the purpose is not to have a discussion, to ask each other questions, or to start a conversation. The purpose is only for each participant to share their perspectives while the others offer their full attention.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- The [article](#) we wrote about Conversation Café



Conversation Café

We agree to ...

1. Suspend judgement
2. Respect one another
3. Seek to understand rather than persuade
4. Invite and honor diverse opinions
5. Speak what has personal heart and meaning
6. Go for honesty and depth without going on and on and on and on ...

Decide who volunteers as a host. The host fully participates, and gently intervenes where necessary to protect the agreements and timeboxes.

1

Everyone takes 1 minute to share their reflections and thoughts on the topic. Only the person with the talking object speaks, and this person decides who gets it next. People may skip a turn.

2

Everyone takes 1 minute to share their reflections and observations on the first round. Only the person with the talking object speaks, and this person decides who gets it next. People may skip a turn.

3

As a group, engage in open, lively conversation about the topic. If you want, you can continue to use the talking object (10-30 min).

4

Everyone takes 1 minute to share their takeaways from the conversation. Only the person with the talking object speaks, and this person decides who goes next. People may skip a turn.



Developed by Keith McCandless & Henri Lipmanowicz.

shop.theliberators.com



Step 4: Define The Product Goal With Nine Whys

So far, you used UX Fishblow to learn the expectations about the product from your stakeholders and Conversation Cafe to reflect on that. This sets the foundation to formulate a clear long-term goal for the Product – the Product Goal.

The outcome of the previous steps is used as input for the Liberating Structure [Nine Whys](#). It helps the Scrum team and its stakeholders define a shared Product Goal. The Product Goal becomes the main reason for working together as a Scrum team. It enables collaboration, focus, and commitment. It also gives meaning to all the Scrum events.

Invitation

"Our product is valuable, important, or desirable to our stakeholders because ..." or "Our product exists in order to ..."

Steps

1. **2 min** Individually, ask everyone (Scrum team and stakeholders) to compile a list of what (will) make(s) the product valuable to them.
2. **2 min** Provide an overview of the steps that are coming up so that people know what to expect once they're in their breakouts.
3. **8 min** Invite everyone to form pairs and move them into separate breakouts. Ideally, the stakeholders pair up with someone from the Scrum team. In the breakouts, people interview each other in turns, 4 min each, about their list. Interviewers only ask "Why is that (item/entire list) important for you?" while taking notes.
4. **8 min** Invite pairs to join another pair in new breakouts. In there, the pairs exchange notes and notice patterns about why people are part of this Scrum team. In the final minutes, ask the groups to complete the sentence "Our product is valuable because ...".
5. **5 min** Back in the main channel, each group briefly presents its purpose statement. Together, pick one that jumps out. Or just notice patterns across the statements.

Examples

- Our product is valuable, important, or desirable because it allows teams to continuously inspect their work as a team and improve their process accordingly;
- Our product is valuable, important, or desirable because it encourages a healthier lifestyle by making it easy for hikers to inspect how many steps they walk on a daily basis;

Our Findings

- Groups can easily get stuck in the process of coming up with a great purpose statement. It is important to work empirically here, too. Start with a quick and raw version and improve it over time as you learn more about this meetup.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Make the Purpose of Your Work Together Clear with 'Nine Whys'](#)

Step 5: Identify Sprint Goals With 25/10 Crowd Sourcing



Now that you have defined a Product Goal, it's a good moment to encourage the Scrum team to identify goals for the upcoming Sprints. These goals won't be set in stone, but are intended to offer clarity and a sense of direction. The Scrum events are used to continuously create transparency about the state of the product, to inspect the progress towards achieving the Product- and Sprint Goal, and to adapt when necessary.

The Liberating Structure [25/10 Crowd Sourcing](#) offers a good way to rapidly capture such ideas and build commitment from people. In this workshop, we'll use it to identify potential Sprint Goals.

Invitation

"Given our Product Goal, what seems to be a good sequence of objectives for the 3-5 upcoming Sprints?"

Steps

1. Share the link to the 25/10 Crowd Sourcing challenge that you prepared earlier in the [free online app](#).
2. **2 min** Individually, ask everyone to silently submit one Sprint Goal they have in mind, for the Scrum team to realize, for the upcoming Sprint.
3. **8 min** Explain the next steps. In a moment, you will be starting the voting session. Ask people to rate each idea on a

scale of 1 to 5, 1 meaning "Meh. I wouldn't commit to this Sprint Goal" and 5 meaning "Yes! I can definitely commit to this Sprint Goal". Start the voting session in the app and move to the next round when people have voted. Repeat five times.

4. **5 min** Conclude the voting and share the link with results from the app with everyone. Briefly collect the top 3 Sprint Goals. Discuss the Sprint Goals with the entire Scrum team, and work together to select one goal for the upcoming Sprint. Make sure to include your Product Owner in the conversation, because in the end, they are accountable for the value delivered by the Scrum team.

Our findings

- 25/10 Crowd Sourcing is purposefully anonymous to give everyone an equal voice. Resist the temptation to ask who suggested an idea (regardless of its score).
- The 25/10 Crowd Sourcing was built by David Heath. David is a friend and an active member of the global Liberating Structures community. [Buy him a coffee](#) if you like it.

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "1-2-4-ALL" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with 1-2-4-ALL](#)



2 min

Step 6: Closing

If you have the time, do a quick debrief with the group. A simple Liberating Structure for this is [Impromptu Networking](#) ("What did you observe, think or feel while participating in this gathering?"). Draw out some salient patterns from the whole group, but keep it short.

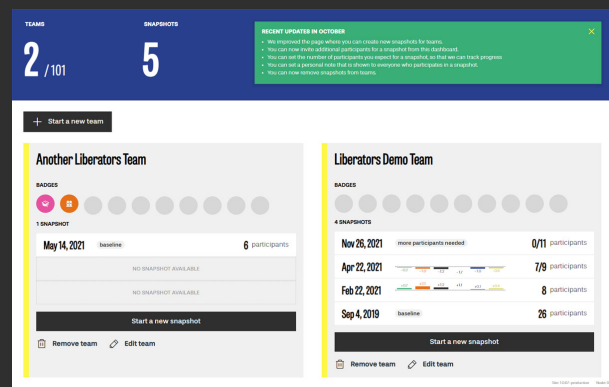
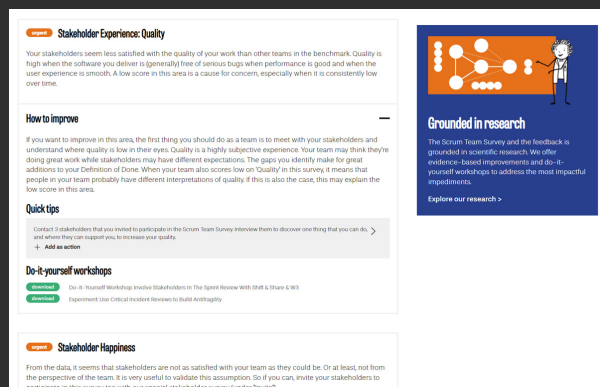
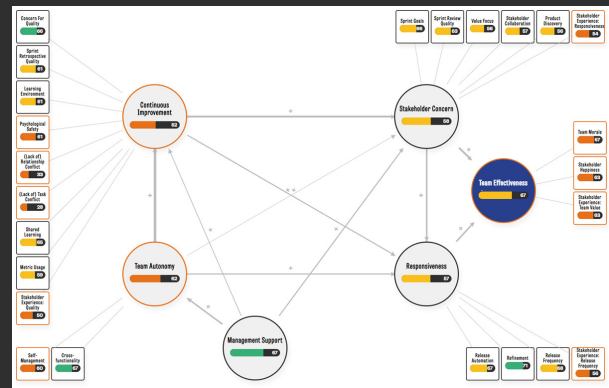
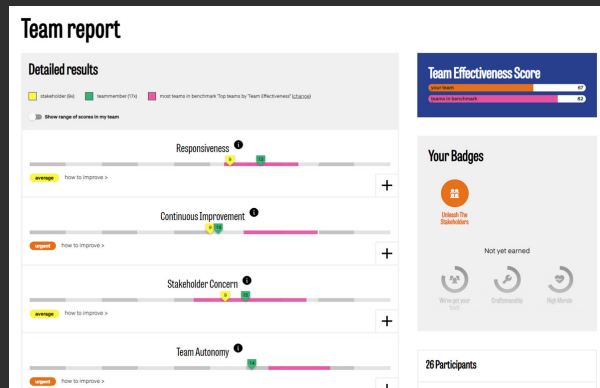
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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